

burners-invocations

Burners Invocations

*There are things in the Dragon Isles older than the kingdoms and hungrier than the sea. They do not answer prayers. They answer **names** — spoken thrice, aloud, by someone reckless enough to want something badly. An Invocation is not a spell. It is a bargain, and the other party has been making bargains since before your language had words.*

An **Invocation** is how a Burner calls on an otherworldly being — a god, a dead power, a d’jinn, a thing from beyond the veil — by its **True Name**, and asks. If it answers, it makes an **Offer** and an **Ask**. What you can get is capped by your **Alignment with that patron**; what it costs is always real.

Invocations are **not Sorcerie** — see [[Burners Principles#Invocations are not Sorcerie]]. Any Burner may attempt one; the fighter kneeling in the barrow-dark has the same standing as the archmage if her Traits lean the patron’s way.

Patrons

A **patron** is any otherworldly being with a True Name and a **nature** — the shape of what it loves, hates, and wants. The gods of the Isles qualify: every one answers to one of the **seven divine archetypes** — Sun King, Earth Mother, Winged Messenger, Veiled Maiden, Winter King, Voiceless Keeper, and the Voice in the Void — and each culture knows them by its own names (Pyrose the Fyrelord, Xohm the Earthmother, Mrmym the Sky Dragon, Lunara the Maiden of Song, Hrivlygg the Frost King, Hruul the Voiceless One, and stranger voices besides — see *Gods of the Dragon Isles* in the world canon). So do lesser and stranger things: a drowned king remembered by one village, a d’jinn in a brass lamp, a deep one under the harbor, the nameless thing a cult calls *the Gardener*.

Nature is the rulebook. Every patron has a nature the Referee holds — what requests it likes, what it refuses, what it shapes its callers toward. The gods seldom leave their Halls; they lend power through those aligned to them, and the stranger things deal more directly and less kindly.

The Referee’s patron card. For each patron in play, the Referee keeps a short private line: its **nature** (two or three words), what it **favors**, what it **refuses**, and a **shaping table** of d6 Traits it molds its callers toward. A patron of storms might

shape *wrathful, restless, sea-longing, loud, fearless, scarred by lightning*; a patron of the veiled moon might shape *patient, secret-keeping, night-eyed, quiet, dream-touched, faithful*.

Alignment with a Patron

Your standing with a patron is an **Alignment** (see *Alignment* in [[Burners Adventure Game]]): count every Trait across all your Approaches that bears on the patron's nature, **divide by 4, round down**. Record it when it matters: *Lunara 2, the Drowned King 1*.

It grows the way everything in Burners grows — through play:

- **Traits.** Take Traits at level-up that lean the patron's way (their shaping Traits count double-sure).
- **Deeds.** Acts in the patron's nature are Traits waiting to be named — the Referee may point at one you've earned.
- **Relics.** Carrying the patron's **Relic** counts **+1 Alignment** with them, for Invocations only.
- **Shaping.** Accepting a pact's shaping Trait (below) deepens the bond by definition.

Alignment	Standing	At the table
0	Stranger	The patron may not hear; an Offer, if any, is thin
1	Known	Small favors, one clear Ask
2	Favored	Serious Offers; shaping sticks
3+	Saint	Their business is yours — see <i>Saints</i>

Patron Alignment is not Sorcerie — see [[Burners Principles#Invocations are not Sorcerie]].

True Names

You cannot invoke what you cannot name. **True Names** hide in myth — runestones, tomb-glyphs, amulet inscriptions, grimoire margins, the waking name of a Relic, the last word of a dying cultist. Beings have **many names**; part of the lore game is learning which ones are true.

Finding or verifying a name is play: a **2d6 + Sorcerie** roll (ancient lore) or **2d6 + Craft** (decipherment, legwork) against Heat, or simply the reward of exploration. *Have I heard this name before? Is this the same being the fisherfolk call the Weeping Mother?* — good questions for the Referee, and every answer is Lore worth a margin note.

Making an Invocation

An Invocation is a **ritual**, not a spell or an attack. You cannot Invoke in the middle of a combat round — gather yourselves before the fight, after, or when the company has bought enough Turns of space (a barred door, a held corridor, broken contact). Rebuking the willful dead follows the same rule: hold the line while the caller works, or wait until the clash pauses.

Time. Each **Offer level** you hope to receive needs about **ten minutes** of ritual — one **Turn** per level. A small favor is one Turn; a middling favor two; a serious favor three. The Offer you actually get is capped by the **lower** of: Turns spent, your **Alignment** with the patron, and what the pageantry can bear.

1. **Pageantry.** Gather yourself spiritually, then prepare a place that would please the being. Lay an altar or makeshift shrine: incense, flame, salt, water, song, food or blood, flowers, bones, Relics, sacred objects — whatever fits that patron's nature. Spend the Turns your intended Offer level requires. **What you prepare (and how long you keep the rite) gates what you may ask.** A thimble of moon-water and a hummed bar of song can carry a small favor from Lunara; it will not carry a rebuke. A fresh sea-altar with kelp, salt, and a Relic may support asking Maren to take a drowned wight home — and companions must hold the space for those Turns. Empty hands and a shout are not an Invocation — they are noise, and the wrong listener may hear.
2. **Declare.** Speak the True Name **thrice**, aloud and formal, and state your request in the fiction — what you want, not a spell title. Ask only what the pageantry can bear. This is not a wish: you ask; the patron decides what your words mean.
3. **Cost.** The Referee quotes a **Cost** — a number to meet or beat: usually **8** for a small favor, **10** for a middling working, **12** for a serious working. **World-tilting requests are refused** before any roll — end the war, raise the dead kingdom, remake a fate. A request **against** the patron's nature raises Cost by 2; one **squarely in their nature**, backed by deeds already done and fitting pageantry, may drop it by 2 — or simply succeed without a roll (as any well-backed deed can). In a hostile place, Cost may be the scene's Heat if that is higher.
4. **Roll. 2d6 + Alignment with the patron** — your Approach roll for this bargain. Meet or beat the Cost and the patron **may answer**. Fall short by the **shortfall**: the unpaid remainder lands as **HP on the caller**, **Heat on the crew**, or **split between them**, as the Referee reads the fiction — speaking a True Name in a barrow is usually personal; working a rite in a tense holdfast usually riles the room.
5. **Answer.** On a made roll, the patron **responds** with an Offer and an Ask — that pair is where the Referee **balances** the bargain (see below). On a miss, silence, a wrong listener, or a price paid for nothing — you still bear the shortfall, and in a bad place the wrong thing may have heard its name spoken thrice.

Pageantry examples

Patron	Small — 1 Turn (Cost 8)	Middling — 2 Turns (Cost 10)	Serious — 3 Turns (Cost 12)
Lunara	Silver coin in clear water; whisper her name over it	White cloth, moon-water, a song sung thrice,	Shrine of silver and night-bloom, harp or choir, Relic on the altar

Patron	Small — 1 Turn (Cost 8)	Middling — 2 Turns (Cost 10)	Serious — 3 Turns (Cost 12)
		a Relic of the moon	
Maren-under-the-Waves	Salt on wet stone; a shell left as courtesy	Kelp, brine-bowl, drowned offering, the Relic comb set open	Sea-altar of black rock, tide-gift of fish or coin, companions silent while the water listens
Pyrose	A clean flame and a scrap of iron	Fyreside, ash-circle, witch-wood or fallen thing burned as tithe	Consecrated pyre, iron crown or brand, Relic in the heat, no shadow between you and the fire

Thin pageantry may still let you Declare — but the Referee caps the request at what the shrine can honor. Ask beyond the pageantry and the Cost climbs, the Offer twists, or the patron does not hear.

The workings of otherworldly beings are mysterious. They may read your request from a different angle and a different sense of time. Word requests with care, or don't — the stories are better when you don't.

Not wishes

Invocations are **patron-shaped**, not player-authored. The roll only decides whether you are **heard** and whether you pay **shortfall** — it does not grant what you asked for. What you get, and what it costs you afterward, is the **Offer and the Ask**.

One open Ask. A patron will not heed a **second** Invocation from you while an Ask from a prior **accepted** pact remains uncleared. If the only debt is a **shaping Trait** you have not taken yet, they wait until you take it at level-up. Spam the names and you still pay the **shortfall** for nothing — Wåndyr tables learned that lesson the hard way.

The Offer and the Ask

When a patron responds, the Referee sets an **Offer level** from **1** up to the **lowest** of: Turns spent on the ritual, your **Alignment with the patron**, and what the pageantry can bear — then an **Ask** to match. **This pair is where the Referee balances the bargain** — not on the Cost roll. The roll only gates whether anyone answers and whether you pay shortfall getting there; the Offer is what the patron actually does with your words (often not what you meant), and the Ask is the real price.

Dial freely within the cap: a **thin Offer** with a **light Ask** for a small favor in nature; a **strong Offer** with a **heavy Ask** when the crew is desperate; a **twisted Offer** that serves the patron's agenda when the request was greedy or off-nature. Alignment 1

does not mint treasure — set Offer level accordingly. World-tilting remains refused at Declare. Refusing the pact costs nothing beyond shortfall already paid; accepting binds you to the Ask.

Offers by level (guidance, not a menu). The level is how large a favor the patron lends.

Level	Scale	Ritual time	Examples
1	Small favor	1 Turn (~10 min)	A door unbarred, a scent on the wind, a candle that will not gutter, a name whispered back
2	Middling favor	2 Turns (~20 min)	Turn the shambling dead from your path, calm a storm long enough to land, mark the liar in the room, close a wound that will not stanch
3	Serious favor	3 Turns (~30 min)	Rebuke a willful dead thing in its name, part a flood long enough to cross, strike one foe with its wrath, carry a message to a far shore
4+	As grave as the caps allow	4+ Turns	Still a serious working — never a remade world

Asks by nature (d6, or the Referee picks):

d6	The Ask
1	A quest — do a deed in its nature, on a clock
2	A taboo — never again do the thing it hates
3	A shaping Trait — become more like its saint (below)
4	Heat owed — the crew carries +2 Heat until a deed discharges it
5	A Relic errand — find, carry, or return something of its
6	

d6	The Ask
	A tithe — treasure, blood, a secret, a song; paid now

You may **accept or refuse**. Refusing costs nothing beyond any **shortfall** already paid on the roll. Accept, and the patron delivers; the Ask is yours until cleared — and patrons remember defaulters better than debtors. **While an Ask is open, that patron will not answer a new Invocation from you.**

Shaping

Patrons mold their callers toward their ideal **saint**. On an accepted pact, the Referee rolls (or picks) from the patron's **shaping table** and names a Trait — *sea-longing, wrathful, grave-keeper, patient as stone*.

- **Already have it?** You are in harmony — no cost, and the patron is pleased.
- **Don't?** Take it at your **next level-up**, free, like any Trait — or, where the pact is narrow, the Referee may offer it as a **Signature** on a Trait you already hold. Until you do, that patron **will not answer another Invocation** from you.
- **Refuse the shaping?** The pact may sour, or the Ask worsens. Patrons do not forget being told no.

Shaping is how Alignment compounds: each pact leaves a Trait that bears on the patron, and the count climbs.

Relics

A **Relic** is a sacred object that serves as **conduit and ark** to a patron — a rallying flag for its power. To the uninitiated a Relic may pass for a cursed or sentient item, since the patron can act through it.

- **Ark.** Carrying a patron's Relic counts **+1 Alignment** with that patron, for Invocations only.
- **Conduit.** A Relic is often a **named item** or **named Arcana** — its true name may be the patron's gift, surrendered through an Invocation.
- **Ledger.** A Relic in the wrong hands is a grievance; returning one is the classic Ask.

Sentient items are the speaking subset — a bound soul or a splinter of the patron itself, capricious, jealous, and unhinged from confinement. A sentient Relic may aid, argue, or betray; it hates being abandoned, rejected, or “cheated on” with a rival item. Carrying one grows your Alignment whether you like where it's growing or not.

Saints

At **Alignment 3+** with a patron, holding their Relic, you may stand as their **saint** for a quest the patron cares about.

- **Blessing.** You may bless companions who take up the quest — those who accept pursue it with fervor, and the Referee may grant the blessing teeth (a bonus die at a decisive moment, a Morale that holds, a wound that waits). Fiction first; no new subsystem.
 - **The price.** A blessed quest abandoned — even by death — leaves the patron a claim. It may **shape** the defaulter's spirit, or collect in stranger coin. Saints are fearless for a reason: their souls are already spoken for.
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The Willful Dead

The mindless dead burn (see *We Burn Undead* in [[Burners Adventure Game]]). The **willful** dead — the lich, the wraith-lord, the vampire in his hall — are an Invocation problem. A Burner aligned to a being whose nature opposes the grave may **rebuke them in the patron's name**: an Invocation with fitting pageantry — **one Turn per Offer level** you can receive — rolled on Alignment, its Offer the rout or barring of the dead thing. You do this before the clash, after, or while companions hold space for the rite — not as a combat Action. That is the Isles' true "turning" — not your holiness, but the patron's, lent through the pact, at the price all pacts carry.

Worked Examples

Small favor — Cost 8

*Torren needs a door in the old lighthouse unbarred. He spends **one Turn**: silver coin in clear water, one verse under Lunara's name. Speaks the True Name thrice, asks her to ease the latch. Cost **8**; Alignment 1; Offer cap **1** (Turns and Alignment). He rolls **2d6+1 = 10**. Offer level 1: the latch softens as if wet with dew. Ask: leave the coin in the cup until dawn — a light tithe. He accepts.*

Middling working — Cost 10

*The crew must land through a rising squall. Briar spends **two Turns** on the deck-rail: white cloth, moon-water, Relic harp-string, song. They ask Lunara to calm the water long enough to beach. Cost **10**; Alignment 2; Offer cap **2**. Roll **2d6+2 = 11**. Offer level 2: the wind drops for one landing. Ask: a taboo — no night-raid against fisherfolk until the next new moon. They accept.*

Serious working — Cost 12

*Sefa (Craft 1, Traits: marsh-lore, night-fisher, drowned-kin, quiet) and companions bar the crypt door while the Cellarer's wight claws beyond. She cannot call mid-clash. Alignment 1 (Relic) caps Offer at **1**, so **one Turn** of sea-altar is enough for*

what she can receive — salt and kelp on wet stone, a drowned fish as tide-gift, Maren's barnacled comb open. She speaks the name thrice and asks Maren to take the dead thing home. Cost 12 (the Ask is serious even if the Offer comes back small). Roll 2d6+1 = 9 — shortfall 3, split as 2 HP on Sefa and +1 Heat on the crew. The sea still answers.

*Offer, level 1: floodwater rises black and cold; the wight wades down as into a mother's arms — gone, not destroyed. Ask: return the comb to the fen shrine before the next full moon, and shaping Trait **sea-longing**. Sefa accepts. Next level-up the Trait is hers — Alignment with Maren starts to climb. (A full serious Offer — level 3 rebuke — would have needed Alignment 3 and three Turns holding the door.)*

Refused — world-tilting

Someone asks Pyrose to burn an enemy kingdom from the map. The Referee refuses before Cost: that is not a serious working; it is a remade world. No roll. The fyreside is still hungry — choosing to light it anyway may draw something else.

Quick Reference

INVOCATION

WHO any Burner who knows the True Name
ALIGN Traits bearing on the patron ÷ 4 (round down); +1 with their Relic
TIME 1 Turn (~10 min) per Offer level hoped for; not a combat Action
PAGEANT altar / incense / sacrifice / Relic / sacred objects; gates the Ask
CALL Name thrice + request (only what the pageantry can bear)
COST 8 small / 10 middling / 12 serious; no world-tilting; ±2 by nature
ROLL 2d6 + Alignment vs Cost — meet it or shortfall → HP and/or Heat
DEBT one open Ask per patron — no second call until cleared
OFFER ≤ min(Turns, Alignment, pageantry); small / middling / serious / grave
ASK quest · taboo · shaping Trait · Heat owed · Relic errand · tithe
SHAPE patron Trait at next level-up (free) or a Signature; refusal sours
NOT spells · Arcana · Sorcerie — any Burner may call